



hardware, and provides stock on Android with a promise of future software upgrade. Read: Android One launch: All you need to know and Google Android One: First impressions & its potential impact in India

The first set of Android One phones were launched in partnership with Micromax, Karbonn and Spice with price starting at ₹6,399.

Praveen Bhadada, Director – Market Expansion, Zinnov, believes Google's initiative has the potential to help people switch from feature phones to

“Android One is a great new beginning and a sign of strategic importance that Google is giving to the Indian market for its mobile play. We believe that Google has got the strategy right by offering a low cost device with quality hardware specs, free data (for apps & YouTube etc.) and free content subscriptions for users. We expect AndroidOne to standardize the smartphone experience across users and drive millions of feature phone users to adopt smartphones in the near future. This opens up tremendous opportunities for device manufacturers, data service providers, app developers and technology retailers in India and other similar emerging markets.”

PwC India Leader (telecom) Mohammad Chowdhury is quoted as saying: “The festive season regularly sees an uptick in handset sales and we should expect this in the next few months. In particular there is hot competition in the segment priced from ₹7,000 upwards.”

Microsoft won't back down

Microsoft, which plans to drop the Nokia brand from its future phones, is making plans to bring down the price point of

In conversation with Peter Chang

The smartphone market in India has recently been infested by a surge in the budget segment. Starting with Motorola, more and more manufacturers are bringing devices to this segment and taking the competition to a whole new level. Among these is Asus, which has turned a number of heads with its Zenfone series (Zenfone 4, Zenfone 5 and Zenfone 6) of smartphones. The company has also been making big announcements globally with its Zenwatch, Zenbooks and tablet devices. It is quite evident that Asus is taking a whole new approach to the industry, leveraging areas where it already has a grasp to take steps in others. We got in touch with Peter Chang, Regional Head, South Asia & Country, Asus over email and asked him a few questions:



Peter Chang, Regional Head, South Asia & Country, Asus

d With the Zenfone series Asus is targeting a select market segment below Rs. 20,000. Do you have plans to make higher end devices?

PC: We launched 3 variants in July, 2014 in India. The series was introduced with targeting masses at large with 4, 5 and 6 inches variants. Within just two months, we have received tremendous response from the masses. The product delivers quality of a high end product yet is available at

very competitive prices. We are now coming up with a 4.5 inch variant which will further offer our existing and prospective users a broad range to choose from. Presently, these variants would be our focus. Users may expect more from our second generation of the series.

d Asus has stuck to its partnership with Intel and the new phones have pretty good performance. But do you plan to bring Snapdragon or MediaTek powered devices in India?

PC: We value our partnership with Intel and have had great experience in delivering superior quality products together. We would be continuing with our association and our promise of delivering incredible along with Intel.

d How many units of the Zenfone have been sold in India so far?

PC: We have almost sold more than one lakh units in India. The numbers are increasing every day and so is the frequency of the stock's availability.

You can read the rest of the interview online at <http://dgit.in/Asus-Interview>

upcoming feature phones and smartphones without compromising on quality of the phones. Microsoft is expected to launch a “First” series of feature phones priced under \$40 (₹2,500 approx).

Microsoft's corporate VP for phones Jo Harlow said, “It is estimated that at least 1 billion people in the world still do not have a mobile phone, while at the same time there is increasing demand for reliable backup phones in both mature and high-growth markets.”

Microsoft has introduced its “First” range of smartphones with the launch of Nokia 130

in early August. The Nokia 130 will be available in India later this year at ₹1500 (approx). Microsoft also have plans to launch the Nokia 225 internet-enabled feature phone under ₹2,500 (approx).

The tech giant has also plans to bring down the price of future Windows Phone based smartphones. Currently, Windows Phones available in the market are priced higher than the Android smartphones with similar set of specifications. Apparently, Microsoft needs to improve on specs as well as bring down the price of devices in the Lumia range in order to

compete with the Android powered smartphones.

With Firefox OS joining the sub 2K smartphone race in India, competition in the the entry level segment has intensified. With a mix of improved hardware and software, Firefox devices could give a good competition to Microsoft in this segment.

Most importantly, the launch of the Android One series of smartphones will further drive the low-cost Android smartphones segment. Microsoft should tap this market right away, or else it might lose even before it starts competing. **d**